archimony

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64752997.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Mara & She-Ra (She-Ra), Adora & Mara (She-Ra), Adora & She-Ra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Character Death, Grief/Mourning, Glimmer is a Good Friend (She-Ra), Bow Is a Good Friend (She-Ra), catra's kinda fcking crazy, i based her off my ex a bit ngl, fck that ho though, Anyways, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), but also hates her, Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Hurt No Comfort, the permanence of death shown through a non-existent afterlife, The Author Regrets Nothing, Author Is Sleep Deprived, Ghosts, Afterlife, Discussion of Mortality, and morality, Morality, Mortality, cause i cant stop myself from talking about morality, mara and adora are such one in the same, Aftermath of Violence, Intimacy, Non-Sexual Intimacy, Platonic Cuddling, Basically, Platonic Soulmates, Adora is in Love with Glimmer (She-Ra), Kind Of, conflicting feelings are CRAZY, allusions to another work of mine

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Adora Dies (Nothing is the Same)

Stats:
Published: 2025-04-16 Completed: 2025-04-21 Words: 8,047 Chapters: 2/2

archimony

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64752997.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Mara & She-Ra (She-Ra), Adora & Mara (She-Ra), Adora & She-Ra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Character Death, Grief/Mourning, Glimmer is a Good Friend (She-Ra), Bow Is a Good Friend (She-Ra), catra's kinda fcking crazy, i based her off my ex a bit ngl, fck that ho though, Anyways, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), but also hates her, Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Hurt No Comfort, the permanence of death shown through a non-existent afterlife, The Author Regrets Nothing, Author Is Sleep Deprived, Ghosts, Afterlife, Discussion of Mortality, and morality, Morality,

Mortality, cause i cant stop myself from talking about morality, mara and adora are such one in the same, Aftermath of Violence, Intimacy, Non-Sexual Intimacy, Platonic Cuddling, Basically, Platonic Soulmates, Adora is in Love with Glimmer (She-Ra), Kind Of, conflicting feelings are CRAZY, allusions to another work of mine

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Adora Dies (Nothing is the Same)

Stats:
Published: 2025-04-16 Completed: 2025-04-21 Words: 8,047
Chapters: 2/2

archimony

by Lukaswritesthings

Summary

Adora died the way she lived; sacrificing herself for the people she loved.
It's only a couple days later, however, when Adora wakes up again.
or; she-ra doesn't let those who grasp it's power rest. adora hates it.

Notes

the title is, again, from john koenigs book "the dictionary of obscure sorrows" because i genuinely love it so much

See the end of the work for more notes

Postexistence

archimony

noun.

"anger about an injustice you only discovered long after the fact, after years have passed and everyone else has moved on, leaving you with an awkward and antiquated righteousness that you're not sure what to do with, like a flywheel still spinning long after the engine has turned off."

-

Waking up felt different. Usually, Adora's eyes snapped open to the feel of soft blankets and bedding beneath her. She'd hear the birds outside cawing for a few minutes before they were scared back into hiding by the sudden hustle and bustle of Brightmoon.

Yet today, her eyes struggled to open. When she finally ripped them apart, the rest of her senses faded back in. She could feel grass beneath her, a confusing sensation compared to what was normal, and the sun was bearing down upon her. For some reason, though she could see and sense it's brightness against her retinas, she could not feel it's heat. Better yet, though she could glare to her left and see the grass, it's poking and prodding against her skin was a light, dull feeling. Like she was barely there.

At first, Adora believed it to be a dream. Obviously, if she was to wake up, she had to have fallen asleep, which meant she should've been in her room. Following that, the dull and fleeting way she perceived the world around her, along with every color she saw having lost it's natural saturation all of a sudden, reminded her of the way a nightmare felt. How she didn't feel real anymore. Or alive.

The second she realized what she had thought, however, her last moments snapped into place within her memory. Running to save somebody, the emptiness within her chest, and the last feeling of touch she could clearly remember, stained with the slippery sensation of hands rubbing against her bloody skin. With it, the remembrance brought a certain longing to feel it all again, though she hadn't been missing it for more than a split second.

What she couldn't clearly remember, however, was the people. She knew who they were, obviously, it was Catra and Glimmer, but their figures were different. Instead of a human body, they had been replaced by fuzzy white clouds, tinged with different colors. Flowing reds and purples cascaded around where they would have been, their voices coming through to Adora like she was under water. It occurred to her that the colors she remembered them as were the only ones she could see.

Adora quickly glanced down, struggling to sit up. It was as if she'd been asleep for days, waking up stiff and sore. The second she found what she was looking for, Adora wished she'd never moved.

A large, gaping hole existed where her chest should have been. It wasn't dripping blood, or really anything at all, but she could see her bones and what she assumed were her organs. She screamed, shuffling backwards with renewed vigor and throwing her head against the ground. She didn't feel the impact.

It hit her all at once, feeling almost like the blast shooting through her all over again. She was dead, stuck with the injury she'd last been given, and somehow still roaming the world. It wasn't the afterlife she'd grown up knowing, the usual Above and Below. It wasn't even the version that she'd learned at the Rebellion. Instead, she was almost senseless, grasping at the faint feeling of grass and dirt beneath her fingertips, praying she didn't catch sight of her wound once more by accident.

She cried, or tried to, gasping and heaving. The tears never came, however. Her eyes didn't even well up with the possibility. Adora screamed, begging and asking "*why?*", using her voice for the first

time since she'd said her last words to Glimmer. Nothing felt real, but she wasn't waking up, either. She knew, for certain, that she had died. She'd sacrificed herself for the person she'd loved since they were children, and in turn, she'd doomed herself.

In the midst of her breakdown, Adora felt a tingling coming from her side. Unwilling to look down and see what it was, Adora kept her eyes crammed shut, fingers wrapped up in blades of grass. The tingling got stronger, however, feeling almost like when Swiftwind was near her or signaling her from afar. With nothing else to do, nowhere to go and nobody to see any time soon, Adora tentatively opened her eyes and glanced to her left.

There, as if a savior hidden in plain sight, a divine gift to repay all of Adora's bad luck, a person stood. They had messy brown hair and tanned skin. At the same time, Adora realized she could see them in *color.* In fascinating, horribly scary color compared to the gray hues surrounding them. Compared to the ones she could see on herself. The person also had many injuries on them. A missing arm, the gruesome sight almost too much for Adora, and an awkwardly bent leg. With all the dirt and grime, it was hard for Adora to recognize them, almost like seeing a family member for the first time in years and having to search their face for a certain freckle or the familiar dimple you'd known all your life.

Akin to that, however, it only took Adora looking the woman in her eyes to realize who exactly it was.

"Mara?" Adora's voice was quiet and broken. It was filled with longing and hope, a slight tinge of surprise, and a fear that neither of them understood.

The woman, Mara, limped forward. It seemed she was stunned into silence. Adora, still reeling from the reality of her death, crawled forward until they met in the middle. She couldn't stand yet, not trusting her body to move any more than it already had, but Adora tilted her head and stared up, reverently, at Mara. The previous She-Ra.

Mara reached down with her hand, shaking, and caressed Adora's face. The blonde flinched, unused to a random person (Though, this wasn't a random person, was it? This was her Mara.) touching her but was still surprised when she could actually feel the touch just as she had before the incident. She leaned into it, eyes closed, raising her own hands to place overtop Mara's but cringing as they crested the empty hole of her chest. Mara's face creased in empathy.

"Oh, Adora. I..." Mara trailed off, her hand falling from Adora's face. It was only right that the woman knew her name, wasn't it? Adora opened her eyes and watched as Mara seemed to get a bit queasy before continuing. "Adora, I never expected to see you here so soon. I never wanted to see you here."

Adora, on instinct, wanted to apologize for the inconvenience. Yet, it felt wrong to do so while still on her knees, as if she was praying to an old god she'd forgotten existed. She slowly pushed herself up, stumbling a bit and being caught by Mara. Weak, tired from everything both mentally and physically, Adora took a moment to savor the feeling of a body against hers, her face stuck in the crook of her predecessors neck.

"I'm so sorry Mara." Adora whispered against her skin. "I-I'm so sorry for being here, and for what happened to you, for not being a better She-Ra-"

Mara cut her off, her hand coming to rest on the back of Adora's head, right under her now-messy ponytail. Her fingers tangled in Adora's hair and Adora could feel the way two or three of them were bent the wrong way. "Adora, you did nothing wrong. You did..." Mara's fingers clenched, pulling on the baby hairs at the nape of Adora's neck and making her hiss. "You did *exactly* what I did. Sacrificed yourself for what you believed was right."

"I shouldn't have." Adora's voice cracked, and she was sure she'd be shedding tears if she was physically capable. "She-Ra was important to Etheria, to everything. They need her. And I killed her."

"You did the *right thing*." Mara whispered into her ear, making Adora shiver. She wished so desperately that she could feel the heat of the other woman's body, because she felt so utterly cold. "The world needed She-Ra... but she'll be back. She always comes back."

Adora then felt confused. Confused, cold, and still slightly alone. Without the strength to pull herself away from Mara, she tried to right herself a bit more by shuffling her feet. Mara pulled back, sending Adora reeling and gripping the woman's shoulders.

"Wha-what do you mean, she comes back?" Adora swayed slightly. Mara put her hand on the side of her neck, trying to help Adora stay standing.

Mara smiled then, almost amused with the question. Adora's eyebrows furrowed in frustration at the warring emotions. If the other woman flip-flopped again, Adora might get whiplash.

"Sorry, sorry." Mara apologized, seeing the blondes expression. She laughed quietly to herself, tilting her head towards her shoulder. "I just... It's been so long since I've been able to talk to anybody, to touch them. Even though I've been around, I almost forgot you weren't brought up knowing about She-Ra."

Adora shook her head. She pulled her hands away from Mara's skin and tangled them together in front of her. "You've been around? You... you grew up knowing about She-Ra? How does she come back? I-I have so many questions to ask you!"

Mara smiled fondly. Her hand left Adora and gestured to the space around them. "Of course I've been around, Adora. What do you think this is? Ever since I died, I've been wandering the planet. The same one I tried to save." Her voice turned wistful, eyes growing misty. "It's why we look like this, I think. We look the same way we did the second our hearts stopped. It's the only way I can rationalize the way I look, why I'm not a thousand different pieces scattered in space."

Adora looked down, looking right back up after she caught a glimpse of her body. "Can you... see color?"

Mara too glanced over Adora. When they met eyes again, Adora could see that same queasy look from earlier in Mara's face. "Only on your body. Everything else... all gray." She shrugged like it was no big deal. "You're the first color I've seen in hundreds of years..."

"So you can see all my... blood?"

"Everything." Mara looked away, off to the side, purposefully avoiding Adora's gaze. "As for the second question, I did grow up knowing about She-Ra. A mage had told my parents that I was going to be very powerful. As I grew, I found the extent of them through training. Legends on Eternia led my village to believe there'd been others like me before, and that a new one would pop up when the previous one had died. I was just another Princess of Power in a long line. When I was old enough to join the planet's efforts at conquest, I did. I never believed what they were doing was good, but I needed to do something with my life, my power. It was either that or become a soldier and fight in a civil war that was going on. I couldn't hurt my own people. Years later, when they'd found this planet, Etheria, they bound my magic to that damned sword in an effort to use me for themselves." Mara frowned, quickly glancing at Adora's eyes and then looking away again. "When Horde Prime came... I tried to destroy everything about She-Ra and save this planet, to save whoever came after me." For once, the brunette turned back to Adora and smiled again. "To save you."

Adora tried to take in the information given to her, both about this supposed afterlife and Eternia, the planet she'd apparently come from. "So you knew that somebody else was meant to take your place? That there was going to be another She-Ra after you sent us to Despondos??"

Mara shrugged again. "I didn't want there to be. Being She-Ra was terrible for me. The constant fame and pressure, the way

they wanted to use my power to destroy other planets, it was... too much. I didn't want that for anyone. But they'd managed to tie my power to this planet. My hope that you wouldn't exist was always a losing game against the fate of magic, Adora. For that, for not being able to save you from the destiny made centuries before you were even born... I am sorry."

"Is that why Light Hope is here instead of our planet?" Adora had questions coming to her faster than she could process the answers she was getting. She wasn't sure she wanted to process anything even. Maybe. laying here in this field of grass forever would feel better. "And who is Horde Prime?"

Mara cringed. "Don't call it "our planet", Adora. It was hardly my planet after we found Etheria, hence the legends that are also here, and it surely isn't yours. You may have been born there, but you were brought here. You grew up here. You're an Etherian, you hear me?" Adora nodded slowly. The conviction in Mara's voice was something she hadn't heard before. She also wasn't certain that she wanted to hear it again.

Mara took a breath and then nodded. "But yes, that is why Light Hope is here. They practically shackled my power here, connecting me to the planet and making the sword into some sort of... conduit. A conduit and a limiter. They believed the next She-Ra, after I died, would be born on this planet. They wanted to train her on home grounds. So they moved the trainer here."

Adora skipped over the parts about the sword. She wouldn't be using it anymore, after all. Could she even call herself She-Ra since she was dead?

Decided not to fall down that train of thought, Adora focused on the unanswered question Mara had left. "Mara, who is Horde Prime?"

Mara's eyes narrowed. In a split-second change, Adora had watched her go from slightly upset to downright *angry.* "Horde Prime is a cold, dreadful dictator. He had the power to make

clones of himself, creating an army of thousands. He used them to conquer any planets he came across. Universes, as well. Not only conquer them, but completely destroy them. He had his sights set on Etheria, and I couldn't let that happen. I couldn't." Mara took a moment to compose herself. Adora let her, trying to take in the information she'd been given without having to ask a thousand different questions. "I sent us into Despondos for *that* reason. It was the only way I could think of to hide the entire planet."

Adora's mind was reeling. For one, growing up in the Horde had painted the Princesses as their biggest enemy. All at once, Mara had created a feeling of inconsequentiality within Adora. Her life had become so small in mere seconds as she'd learned who Horde Prime was. A universal threat made even fighting the Horde themselves seem meaningless. Wait...

"The Horde... Horde Prime has something to do with them, doesn't he? I mean, surely not because he hasn't reached Etheria, right? But the names are so similar it can't be a coincidence."

Mara's face hardened again. She seemed more sorrowful than angry this time. "Like I said, I've been around since I died. I've listened in on many conversations in the past thousand years. I... there are some things I refuse to explain, Adora. Not because I don't want you to know, but please understand that my feelings on this matter are complex, to say the least." She turned completely to the side, looking towards the bright gray ball in the sky. "I have gone through so much regret and guilt, thinking of how I sent this planet into a starless dimension for nothing. I deprived the people of this world so much culture and light and I sacrificed my life for nothing at all. What kind of She-Ra does that make me?"

Adora felt something within her reach out and grasp something within Mara. Thousands of years separated the two, and before Adora's death, the veil between the normal world and whatever out-of-touch reality they were in did as well. However, they were so similar. Had the She-Ra's before them shared the same concerns and self-doubts as they did?

On a whim, Adora reached out and wrapped her arms around Mara. The woman stiffened before relaxing completely. Adora was sure she understood the feeling well. A realization that you could rest after so many years of fighting. Or maybe, just the simple realization that you weren't alone.

"We have the rest of eternity to spend questioning everything we've done." Adora's voice was muffled by Mara's shoulder, so they shifted until it was a more practical hug and the blonde continued. "But where does that get us? Can we change things? Are we the only people here? What's the point of rethinking the past when everything we've done is set in stone?"

Mara put her arm around Adora's shoulder in turn, putting her chin on the girls head. It occurred to Adora that the other woman had more than a few inches on her. They stood there in silent for a minute, soaking in the comfort of somebody who understood everything about you without you needing to speak.

"I know you were probably being rhetorical," Mara mumbled. "But as far as I know, we are the only people here. Maybe it's She-Ra's magic, maybe we just have really bad luck. But I've been all over Etheria. You're the only person I've seen." Her grip on the blonde tightened, almost possessively, and Adora wondered what that must have been like. Truthfully, Adora had basically gone from a militaristic upbringing to a close, tight-knit community. She'd never been physically alone, even though she'd felt it a lot. Just the thought of never seeing anybody ever again had Adora returning the tight grip, shoving her face into Maras neck once more. She also wondered if this was what a kid felt like, running to their mom after a horrible nightmare.

"It's... not all bad though, I suppose." Mara commented after a few more minutes of silence. Adora didn't dare move to question her, making a noise in the back of her throat as she felt Mara move. The brunette shushed her, her hand tangling in Adora's hair again and undoing the ponytail. The blonde sighed as her hair fell around her head. She could hardly feel it, but the psuedo-tightness that had been nagging at her skull was relieved.

"We don't have to move right now." Mara assured. "But I think you might enjoy what I want to show you. Being unseen and able to go anywhere is kind of fun, you know."

Adora grumbled in distaste. She didn't want to see people enjoying the life she could no longer have. It actually sounded like the opposite of fun. The entire situation angered her, really. Why were they forced to live forever, practically, all alone? Why did everybody else get to rest? Did they not deserve it? After everything they'd done and been through?

Mara seemed to sense Adora's thoughts, almost seeing through the other girl. She leaned down a bit to whisper into Adora's ear teasingly. "You know, we could go see your friends. Even your little Catra."

Suddenly, Adora couldn't get moving sooner.

Death is Infinite

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Mara visit Adora's friends. However, in doing so, they witness a horrifying sequence of events that leave Adora nauseous and broken beyond repair.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora and Mara agreed to see Catra first. Adora wanted to know what was happening with the person she'd given her life for, and Mara reasoned that they literally had the rest of existence to see everything they wanted to. Adora, trying to ignore the sinking feeling that thought gave her, was the first to move away. She almost regretted the loss of Mara's touch.

They'd reached the Frightzone in a few hours. It was a boring walk, with Adora filling it with mindless jabber about her and Catra's relationship. Mara listened diligently, comparing it to her and Light Hope. While Adora didn't really get the way somebody could be so close to the hologram, she was glad somebody understood. Glimmer never really had.

Just like it had been before, the Frightzone was big and imposing upon Adora. It looked even meaner without color. Adora wished she could look at the ugly greens that made up the cold metal of each building. All she could remember was a big blob of white with a slight green tint swirling endlessly in her brain. If she could still feel things she was sure she'd have a headache.

"You ready to find her?" Mara asked. They were stood side by side near an opening in the wall created by cadets that came long before Adora had. Mara's face looked slightly more dirty and grimier, though Adora wondered if she was just seeing things differently as she stalled for time.

The truth was, she wasn't ready to see Catra. She wasn't ready to open Schrodinger's box and figure out whether Catra was perfectly fine after everything or if Adora's death had affected her. It was an anxiety inducing situation that Adora wished she wasn't part of.

"And we can't like... go through walls or anything? Aren't ghosts supposed to be able to do that?"

Mara gave her a weird look, probably because they'd had this talk just an hour ago, but clarified anyway. "No, we can't. No clue why, but I guess that's just another object for She-Ra to overcome."

Again, Adora felt a small bit of anger roil in her stomach. Did She-Ra's entire existence, both pre and posthumous, have to be filled with obstacles? Were they doomed to fight *something*, work against *something*, forever?

"Yeah, okay..." Adora took a deep breath. It shocked her, almost, when she couldn't smell or taste the thick smoke and scent of oil that usually surrounded the Frightzone, even though she knew her senses were practically non-existent. "Let's, uh... let's find her, I guess."

The two of them climbed through the hole and made their way to an entrance door. Since neither of them could interact with the world, they had to wait for a guard to open it and slip through the space left behind. From there, they wandered the halls towards the Force Captain barracks. Adora obviously had no clue where Catra was, but they were a few places that it was likely she could be. Adora figured they'd at least be able to find her if they knew where she wasn't.

As they walked through the winding halls, Mara stopped in front of a short hallway. Adora stopped with her, a shiver running down her spine as she recognized the door to Hordak's sanctum.

"Do you hear that?" Mara asked, eyes squinted in focus as she stared at the large door. Adora frowned, stepping forward to try

and hear whatever had confounded her elder. With widening eyes, she could faintly hear yelling coming from inside the room. It sounded like a man, and a very familiar voice cut through the air after it. Adora stepped forward again, ready to slam the door open before remembering their situation.

With a groan, she beckoned Mara over. "Come on, there's a vent that's always open to the left up here. I think that little imp thing uses it to get through undetected, but it should be open on the other side too."

The brunette nodded. Adora watched her glance down at her missing arm, and she had the split second wonder of how Mara was going to pull herself up into the vent before realizing she'd just have to send Mara in first. When they found the opening in the wall, Adora propped Mara up, made sure she was fully in and out of the way, then hauled herself up afterwards. It was a tight fit, not even enough room to turn around fully.

They took a few turns, almost climbing directly uphill at some points. Adora found herself pacing her rate around Mara, who struggled more due to her injuries. It was easy going, physically, but Adora could hear the voices getting clearer and grimaced when she realized it was Hordak and Catra yelling at each other.

Mara suddenly stopped. Adora tried to peer around her body, but found herself basically blind. "What's up?"

Mara moaned in discontent and tilted her head back. "It's open like you said, but we're really high up."

"So?" Adora asked. As far as she knew they could no longer feel pain, so if they fell from some height they should've been fine, right?

"We'll have to sit on a pipe since we're too high."

Ah. That sounded less than pleasing. It sounded like they were higher up than Adora had originally assumed. She'd never used this vent system herself, because it was practically a death

sentence, but plenty of other cadets had climbed through it's twisting path and bragged about it. Adora supposed they'd never gotten to the end.

Adora nudged Mara forward. The brunette slowly shuffled until she was completely out of the vent. Adora saw it now. At least fifty feet up, above in what should have been the rafters of Hordak's sanctum, a thick pipe came out below the vent shaft. Mara was clearly uncomfortable at the height even though they were immune to damage. Adora reached out, briefly touching the tips of her fingers to Mara's ankle, right above her shoe. Mara twitched, but kept crawling until Adora could fit on the pipe next to her. From there, the view was clear.

Down below, Catra, in all her grayscale glory, was hidden behind a post. Hordak was scouring his room for her, just missing her each time before the magi-cat moved and hid behind a different object. Throughout the game of cat and mouse, they were yelling. Adora leaned forward, watching raptly, and listened into what they were saying.

"-everything! From start to finish, I only have you and that stupid witch to blame!" Catra screamed. She jumped from behind the piles of boxes she'd been using as cover and smacked the imp out of the air from where it had been about to descend on her. It shrieked, trying to bite her ankle, the closest part of her to it, before the magi-cat kicked it away and growled. It flew across the floor until it hit a large piece of what Adora assumed was metal, going still after a loud *thunk* sounded out. Hordak snapped towards her, locking on and snarling.

"You insolent feline! You think you can come into my sanctum and get away with this? How many times do you have to be beaten into the dust before you get sick of the taste of dirt?"

Catra jumped out of the way of a blast from a canon attached to his arm, breathing heavily and landing on a hanging wire just a bit below the two She-Ras.

Adora's breath hitched. Catra had changed her look. The longer sleeves she'd taken made her look so much older than she had the day Adora had died. With the lessened proximity between them, Adora wished Catra would turn her head just right and they'd lock eyes again. A pang of despair hit her as she realized she'd never do that with anyone but Mara again. Thinking about it, she bit her lip and leaned into the other woman, who was now sitting upright next to her. Mara, somehow understanding what she needed without either of them speaking, wrapped her arm around Adora and drew small circles with her fingers.

"It's funny that you think I'm the one who's going to be beaten into the dirt." Catra quipped. Adora had always known her friend to be a troublemaker, especially towards authority figures, but this was a new high. What the hell was she thinking? Was she trying to get herself killed?

Was she?

"No, Hordak. You've got it all wrong." Catra's voice was deadly calm in comparison to their previous yelling match. It made Adora's spine crawl. "I'm going to dismantle the Horde from the inside out. I'm killing the Hydra."

Hordak laughed. His arm-cannon thing waved around the room, trying to pinpoint where Catra was so he could end her. Adora found herself grabbing onto Mara's hand and gripping it tightly, her anxiety rising at the scene in front of her. Mara leaned over and whispered, "Do you know what's going on?". Adora shook her head.

"Really? And how do you plan to do that? You'd have to kill me. And on the off-chance you did, somebody would take my place. Likely that sorceress you spoke of earlier."

It was Catra's turn to laugh then, a high-pitched and keening sound. "Shadow Weaver's already dead, you idiot."

Adora froze. The woman that had raised her, a horrible woman, the one who'd ruined her and Catra's lives, dead? Just like that? How had Catra even found her, if she was at Brightmoon in a holding cell? Hordak froze as well, his arm that held the blaster up shaking. He seemed just as shocked as Adora, if not more so. What had happened to Catra after she'd died? Adora couldn't even comprehend the sentence before Catra continued, her face a steely anger now.

"That's one head down, boss. And I'm about to finish the last two off, starting with..." She trailed off. Adora watched her prowl across the wire and jump from ledge to ledge until she was right behind Hordak. Hordak was stock-still, anger fading into his face. He poised to yell something out just as Catra crouched.

"... you!" She yelled, jumping down from her ledge. Her feet implanted themselves against the Horde Lord's back. A hand came to grab at his chin, yanking his head back and pinning him in a backwards *C*. In a flurry of movements, Adora watched Catra whip her claws out with her other hand and swipe them across his taut neck. Bright green spilled out as he choked and twitched in Catra's deft hands. Adora could have sworn she saw Catra squeeze his chin and drag her nails into it as she pulled away. Jumping off of the man, Catra landed in a crouch but fumbled and hit the ground. She stayed there, surprisingly, and curled into a ball. Adora watched as the magi-cat breathed heavily.

"Holy shit." Mara finally said. Both of the girls on the pipe had been stunned into silence throughout the entire scene. Adora was shaking against Mara, unable to tear her eyes from her best friend's heaving form. "*Holy shit.*"

Adora shoved away from Mara quickly, crawling back through the pipe. The other woman called to her, following behind her as quick as she could. Only when they finally reached the end, gingerly crawling out of the vent, did Adora speak again. It felt like she couldn't disturb the silence that had fallen in the room.

"What the fuck was that? Catra just... she killed Hordak! And also Shadow Weaver? How? Why?" Adora paced back and forth as she spoke, her hands coming up to tangle into and pull at her hair. Mara stretched a hand out, almost like she was going to stop Adora, but was interrupted by the door next to them opening. They both froze as Catra slowly stepped out, holding the unconscious imp in her stained hand. Only then did Adora notice the dried, almost dark brown blood on her face, a stark difference to the bright green liquid covering her arms.

Catra huffed, reaching the end of the hallway and glancing back and forth. Seemingly seeing nothing, she backed up towards the now closed door again and leaned against it.

"Fuck." She muttered. The woman dropped the imp next to her, staring at it for a minute. "... Can't take you to Brightmoon with me. Gotta 'eave you with Kyle and 'nie." Her words were slurred, as if she was drunk. Adora wondered if it was the shock of killing two people she'd known all her life. Her pupils were blown out wide and her eyes were much the same. Misty as she looked around, very obviously not seeing anything she set her gaze on. "'N Rogelio too."

Adora then realized the first thing Catra had said. "You're going to Brightmoon?" She asked, thinking for a second that her friend would respond. She yearned to reach out and gently clean the woman's body. She wanted to hold her and comfort her. She wished they could've run away and hidden together in the woods, away from the war and bloodshed,

Mara stepped forward, taking Adora's hand in her own. The touch felt dirty suddenly, as if she was never meant to have it. She supposed she wasn't, not for many years at least. Yet, despite how it made her heart ache and her gut lurch, she tugged Mara closer and they both watched Catra for a minute.

Finally, after roughly ten minutes, Catra stood up and grabbed the imp again. She made her way out of the hallway and for once, Adora didn't want to follow her.

"Brightmoon." The blonde whispered. "We have to get there before her."

Mara shook her head, squeezing Adora's hand. "You have to slow down, Adora. What we just watched was disturbing and frankly, I don't want to leave without talking about it."

Adora groaned, pulling her hand away. She remembered the warmth of her alcohol, of the bottles she'd constantly down when her life got hard or annoying. It was another thing she dearly missed. She wished she could take a drink and forget everything. "Let's go, okay? We don't know when Catra's going to get there or what she's going to do. And we should see Glimmer... a-and Bow, too." Adora stopped herself before she began to ramble.

Mara made a move to talk again, drawing her hand up to her chest like she'd been burned. Adora had a faint memory of herself doing the same all those years ago when Catra had pulled away from her. When did the roles switch so much?

Mara twitched. Her mouth closed and opened again until she finally spoke. "Okay." Mara said simply. And it was done. They made their way back out through the same way they'd come in, waiting for a guard to open the door just like they had before. The trek to Brightmoon was silent. It took them a good few hours to reach the palace.

Again, without the color, it looked much scarier. Adora once more yearned to see it's pastel colors in full view instead of the blob that resided in her mind. Not wanting to stand around for much longer, Adora marched through the front door. Reaching the top, she faltered as the throne, usually occupied by Angella, was instead occupied by Glimmer. While Adora had seen Glimmer in the cloak many times since her coronation, she'd had yet to see her friend on the throne. Seeing it now, Adora realized just how similar to the previous queen Glimmer looked. She took a shaky breath in as Bow appeared from the side of the imposing room. Glimmer barely looked up from where she had been slumped over

the arm of her seat as the man approached, placing a hand on her forearm. Glimmer flinched at the touch before leaning into it.

"Did you eat breakfast today?" Bow asked. His voice carried through the otherwise silent room. Adora watched as the guards lining the walls gave each other glances.

Glimmer scoffed. She went to respond before falling silent. "... No." She replied quietly.

"And lunch?"

Glimmer's silence was answer enough.

Adora's heart broke for her best friend. She slowly moved towards the throne, dragging her feet behind her. Though she didn't see it, Mara watched her solemnly for a moment before following.

Bow took to rubbing her shoulder soothingly. "You have to eat, Glim. You know Ado-... she'd hate seeing you like this." Bow's voice caught as he tried to speak her name. He winced and looked away for a moment.

Adora clenched her fist. She wanted to agree with him, to force Glimmer to sit next to her at the table and eat her food. She wanted to force the queen into taking care of herself. But she couldn't. Instead, she was forced to sit there and watch her friends suffer as people like Hordak got to rest easy. Adora felt that same anger from before bubble up inside her.

"Adora doesn't want much of anything." Glimmer spat. It lacked the venom it was supposed to have, however, as her voice wobbled and tears formed in her yes. "How am I supposed to eat when one of my best friends is dead? She was supposed to be here and help me after mom and now..."

Bow's brow furrowed. "Are you... mad, at her?" He asked slowly.

"Yes!" Glimmer shouted. Adora flinched and felt the anger replace itself with anguish. Her friend had every right to be upset at her.

"No..." Glimmer continued. "I don't know. How am I supposed to feel? She's gone and I can't even ask her why she did it. I barely got to say goodbye... She told me she loved me, you know?" Glimmer's form shook and Bow leaned forward to hug her. She shoved her face in his shoulder, crying freely. Adora felt a funny feeling form in her stomach as she remembered her last words to Glimmer.

"I love you, Glim."

"I love you too, Adora."

She faintly remembered Glimmer's lips on her shoulder right before she died. At that moment, Adora had just wanted her friend to know she cared about her. She'd even told Glimmer to tell the others the same. Now, Adora wondered what crossed the line between friendship and something more. She remembered the night where her and Glimmer had gotten drunk and Glimmer had confessed to her. It was all faint after that, the drunken haze in her mind too thick to pierce through. Even more now, the conflicting feeling swirling in Adora's mind, torn between the enemy and her closest friend, Adora wanted to touch something other than another ghost.

"I know." Bow replied, almost too quiet for Adora to hear. She moved even closer, stopping on the first step to the throne. "You told me already."

Glimmer nodded as she cried. "Y-yeah, but you don't *know*. She's laying there in front of me, *dying*, and the only thing she can say is *I love you*. And all I can do is hold her and say it back. I couldn't do anything but whisper sweet nothings in her ear, a-and then I pull back and-" She cuts herself off from saying the last part of her sentence, instead turning her head to hide her face against Bow's skin. He rubs her back, hiding tears of his own as they cry together.

Watching two of her closest friends mourn together breaks something inside of Adora. Nobody was meant to see the

aftermath of their own death. Nobody was meant to be around to watch their relationships fall apart and crumble. But Adora was forced to. Adora, She-Ra, the stupid curse that the universe decided to place on her, the entire reason her life was as fucked up as it was. It was like the world's worst joke, leaving the audience to laugh at Adora as she slipped across the stage and just kept *falling.*

Adora goes to yell, to ask Mara a thousand questions about why they have to be here, and if there's any way to end it, but is cut off by a guard running up the center of the room. Mara shivers as the person passes through her, wrapping her arm around her midsection.

Winded, the guard takes a moment before speaking. "Your Majesty!"

Glimmer, quickly trying to compose herself and shove Bow away, to his disappointment, schools her expression. She can't hide the redness of her eyes nor the red tracks down her cheeks. "What is it?"

"There's a Horde soldier here who says she has to speak to you!" After a tense moment, they speak again. "She has dried blood and other liquids on her, my Queen."

Glimmer tensed up. From next to her, Bow put a hand on the arm of her throne, eyes wide and focused. Immediately, it seemed like they were ready for a fight. However, Adora had a feeling she knew who this was.

"Catra." She whispered. Mara gave her a once over before looking towards the open area where the soldier had come from.

"Bring her in." Glimmer ordered.

Nodding, the soldier yelled something over her shoulder. Two other rebellion soldiers appeared from the entrance, a surprisingly lax Catra held between them. She hadn't changed

much since the last time Adora had seen her, though the bright green liquid on her had darkened a bit and dried.

Glimmer bristled. She waited until the trio was as close as they were goin to get before speaking. "*Catra.* What the hell are you doing here, Horde Scum?"

Catra stayed silent for a moment, eyes on the ground. Bow's knuckles whitened as he gripped the edge of the throne. Both of them looked just about ready to beat the woman in front of them and be done with it, which was surprising for Bow, the usual pacifist of the group.

"I bring a message."

Glimmer groaned when Catra didn't speak up after that. "Out with it then!"

Catra finally looked up, piercing the queen with her mismatched eyes. The blood smattered across her face made the dead stare that much more unsettling. "Lord Hordak and Shadow Weaver are dead."

Glimmer froze. It seemed everybody did when faced with that news. Bow made a surprised sound, unable to do much else. "What? How? Shadow Weaver was in a cell here. And Hordak?"

Catra seemed lighter now that she'd said that. "I killed them. Shadow Weaver first. It's not surprising that the witch tried to escape this hellhole. I caught her in the Black Garnet's chamber and got it over with. Hordak was a bit harder, but..." She shook her hands, which were tied up, emphasizing the green liquid that covered them.

Glimmer looked thoroughly disturbed now, along with Bow who looked queasy. "So, you kill them and then you come surrender?"

Catra chuckled and shook her head. "I killed them to get rid of the last reminders of Adora." She spat the sentence out as if it hurt her to do so. It was quiet for what seemed like forever before she

sighed and spoke again. "I killed them because they started this whole thing. They're the reason that she's... They made me hate her so much and now she's gone." Shaking her head again, this time to rid herself of the thoughts running through her head.

Adora watched the interaction, feeling less and less like she was actually there. It was nauseating to watch. Catra would never give herself up to the Rebellion, yet here she was, explaining how she dismantled the very thing they were fighting for the past four years.

"And no, I didn't come to surrender, either."

Glimmer scoffed. "What, you think you can escape now?"

Catra simply shrugged. "I came to tell you that the Horde probably won't want to fight you anymore. You're free of it's grasp. You can stop fighting this war. I figured I could do one good thing and tell you that... It's what Adora would have wanted."

Adora wanted so badly to be alive. She *wanted* so *much.*

"But I don't plan on being taken into custody either." Catra took a deep breath, mumbling something to herself that sounded like, *"Time for the last head*.". Adora watched as Catra pressed her tongue against her cheek, slowly moving it up and biting down on something. She looked up at Glimmer again before her eyes drifted over to where Adora was. The blonde shivered and watched with wide, terrified eyes as Catra swallowed.

It was so obvious when she put everything together. She remembered stories of old commanders getting captured by Princesses and biting down on the cyanide bullets they'd hidden in their mouths. A quick, yet painful death that stopped them from divulging information.

Everything clicked into place when Catra's eyes rolled into the back of her head and she went stiff, body shaking and falling to the floor. The guards tried to catch her, but it was too late.

Glimmer shouted something, sending Bow leaping off the platform and kneeling by the magi-cats side. He pressed a hand to her jugular, likely checking for her pulse, and rolled her over onto her side. Glimmer threw a hand out, ordering the guards to get a healer.

It was all fruitless, Adora knew. The pills killed you the instant they were ingested. You were done the second you swallowed. The blonde sat there and watched people fawn over the dead woman before they all moved aside, letting the healer pronounce her as such and order her body taken away. To where, Adora didn't know. She'd shut the entire world out the second her best friend had bitten down on the small capsule she'd likely grabbed from Hordak's sanctum before she'd left. It was disgusting to Adora to think that she'd probably had the small tablet in her pocket when they'd last seen her. And Adora could do nothing to stop it.

Adora stared. Mara was next to her, her hand running over the blonde's back in an attempt to coax her back to life, but she could do nothing. Something inside Adora was gone. What it was, she didn't know. Truthfully, she didn't very much care, either. It was minutes later, after Catra's body was moved, and everybody had left the room, that Adora spoke.

"How long did it take for me to wake up?"

"What?" Mara asked. She was shocked by the question and the fact that Adora had said anything at all.

"How long did you wait before I woke up again?" Adora repeated herself, her voice devoid of emotion.

Mara fumbled with her words, shaking her head. "Adora, nobody else except you and me woke up again. It has to be She-Ra, Catra won't wake up-"

Adora cut her off, moving forward and relieving herself of the weight of Mara's touch. "I'll wait." With shaky, uncoordinated

motions, she sat down where Catra's body had last been. She'd find out where they took her later, and she'd follow them there, too. For now, she didn't think she could handle seeing Catra's dead form again.

"Adora, you can't just stay here."

"Please, leave." Adora asked, no, begged the other woman. "Please."

"Adora-"

"*Mara, please.*"

There was something about Adora's voice that disturbed her. Whatever the reason, whatever had reached her, Mara backed away.

"I'm coming back for you in two weeks, you hear me? Two weeks." That was the last thing Adora heard before her predecessor left, and she was alone.

Adora waited. She didn't move for a long time, until the sun set and rose again. When it was midday, Adora wandered the castle in a daze, listening to whispers about what they had done with her Catra. She followed the whispers until she reached a small grave off to the side of the cemetery next to the castle. It was away from the rest of the graves, and it's headstone was devoid of writing, but Adora knew who it was. She sat down, flopping against the cold stone slab.

And she waited some more. Hours turned into days, which turned into weeks, and before she knew it, Mara was standing in front of her again. Adora didn't hear anything the brunette said. Instead, she let herself be pulled up and away from the cemetery, sparing one last glance at the gravestone.

Unlike Catra, who was obviously not coming back, Adora had the rest of eternity to sit around and do nothing. To think about the things she had done and caused.

I'll find a way back to you, Catra. I promise.

Chapter End Notes

hey y'all! i didn't want to be too gratuitous with the violence in this one because this mini-fic was more focused on emotions, but i also wanted to capture how the death and fighting would feel in the moment. i pray i did it good enough. as always have a wonderful day!

End Notes

i've been thinking a lot about what i believe in. truthfully, i think most of my fics have become a think-piece on my morals and inner thoughts. lately, though, i've been stuck on the afterlife. there's thousands of videos on ghosts and "paranormal" things, and some times i want to believe them. at my lowest points, i beg to be able to stay with my loved ones and watch over them. other times, most times, i yearn for the experience of not existing. the thought of having to stay awake eternally and watch suffering without being able to stop things, save people, or change minds sounds like a never-ending torture. in this, i wanted to explore that. i hope i hit that mark for everybody! have a great day!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!